of our own times to complete what they had started: that exceptional epigraphist Iravatham Mahadevan, who as I write is still very much with us at the ripe old age of eighty-seven.

Born of a Tamil Brahmin family in Thanjavur in 1930, Dr Mahadevan began his professional life as a member of the Indian Administrative Service, successors of the colonial Indian Civil Service. After five years in Coimbatore he was posted to a desk job in Delhi where he met the veteran historian K. A. N. Sastri, who suggested he might be the right man to take another look at what Subrahmanya Aiyer had claimed to be early Tamil inscriptions in caves. That opportunity came in 1962 when Mahadevan secured a posting to the Government of Tamil Nadu's Industrial Department in Madras (soon to become Chennai) as Director of Handlooms and Textiles. This allowed him to spend his weekends and leaves going over both old ground and new – although it was not until 1965 that he began the first of a series of dramatic discoveries that made his name as an outstanding interpreter of ancient inscriptions.

In February of that year Mahadevan made his first visit to Pugalur, on the south bank of the upper course of the Cauvery River some 15 kilometres from Karur, the ancient Chera capital. On the southern slopes of a hill overlooking the river were two caves, both known to have inscriptions. The brow of the first cave bore two, both said to be damaged and unreadable. 'I had come prepared to see a damaged or fragmentary inscription,' wrote Mahadevan. 'What I saw was a weather-worn inscription which was otherwise not damaged at all … As I read the words *ko*, *atan* and *irumporai*, I realised with astonishment that the inscription was indeed the record of a Cera [Chera] king of the Irumporai line which ruled from Karur in the Cankan [Sangam] Age.'[22] Owing to imperfect copying their significance had been missed. Mahadevan's new reading